

# Three Arguments Against Sola Scriptura

*Sola Scriptura is the Protestant doctrine that the Bible is the sole inerrant authority for Christian faith and practice. It's often assumed to have originated in the early church.*

## I THE ARGUMENT FROM AVAILABILITY

### I — AVAILABILITY: THE BIBLE WASN'T THERE

*The Bible as we know it didn't exist until hundreds of years after the birth of the church.*

#### CANON FORMATION

- **No inspired table of contents** — the New Testament canon selection process was fully human, disorganized, and inconsistent. Church leaders scattered across the Roman Empire accepted or rejected various writings independently (see next section).
- **Centuries-long process** — canon unofficially settled by Athanasius' 39th Festal Letter in 367, but no official decree was issued

#### SIGNIFICANT EXCLUDED WRITINGS

| <i>All of the following were considered authoritative by various Christian communities during the earliest centuries of the church.</i> |                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| WRITING                                                                                                                                 | MANUSCRIPT PRESENCE / NOTES                                                                                                                                                                 |
| Gospel of Thomas                                                                                                                        | Contains 114 sayings of Jesus, but no narrative of his life (or death or resurrection); possibly Gnostic                                                                                    |
| Gospel of Peter                                                                                                                         | Strongly anti-Jewish, and possibly Docetic                                                                                                                                                  |
| Acts of Paul                                                                                                                            | The source of the legendary physical description of Paul (small stature, bald, big nose, crooked legs)                                                                                      |
| Acts of Peter                                                                                                                           | The source of the tradition that Peter was crucified upside down in Rome                                                                                                                    |
| Epistle to the Laodiceans                                                                                                               | Purportedly the letter Paul references in Col 4:16; popular in the western churches for 1,000+ years                                                                                        |
| Epistle of Barnabas                                                                                                                     | Included in Codex Sinaiticus (~350 CE), one of the earliest complete New Testament manuscripts                                                                                              |
| Apocalypse of Peter                                                                                                                     | Included in the Muratorian Canon (~180 CE) and Codex Claromontanus (~550 CE); it's a guided tour of heaven and hell with graphic imagery                                                    |
| Shepherd of Hermas                                                                                                                      | Included in Codex Sinaiticus; quoted as scripture by many 2nd- and 3rd-century church leaders; it seems to be heavily influenced by the Epistle of James                                    |
| Didache                                                                                                                                 | Quoted as scripture by two 2nd-century church leaders; it's a church manual with instructions about baptism, fasting, prayer, the Lord's Supper, and the treatment of prophets and apostles |
| 1 & 2 Clement                                                                                                                           | Late-1st-century letters from Bishop Clement of Rome to Corinth; both are in Codex Alexandrinus (~450 CE)                                                                                   |

#### NEW TESTAMENT ACCESSIBILITY TIMELINE

|                                |                                                                                                             |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>1st &amp; 2nd centuries</b> | New Testament writings circulate individually; no unified collection                                        |
| <b>~200 CE</b>                 | Four gospels + Paul's letters widely accepted as the "nucleus", but other writings remain on the fringe     |
| <b>Late 300s</b>               | Canon informally settled                                                                                    |
| <b>~400-1400s</b>              | Bibles confined to churches and monasteries; population largely illiterate and poor; every copy handwritten |
| <b>~1440</b>                   | Printing press invented; Bibles begin reaching privileged people                                            |
| <b>1517</b>                    | Martin Luther pioneers Sola Scriptura, but literacy remains low for centuries afterward                     |

#### BOTTOM LINE

For the first ~70% of Christian history, Sola Scriptura was impossible.

## II THE ARGUMENT FROM ANARCHY

### II — ANARCHY: THE BIBLE DIVIDES

*Widespread Bible availability created a new problem: interpretive chaos with no authoritative resolution mechanism.*

#### THE CHURCH'S STRUCTURAL PROBLEM

- **No systematic dispute resolution** provided in the New Testament — no modern apostles, no binding councils, no courts or judges

#### THE CHURCH'S PRACTICAL PROBLEM

- **Personal interpretation** — the average churchgoer is not equipped to handle complicated and confusing theological topics on their own (thus the existence of hundreds of different Bible commentaries and other reference tools)
- **Proof-texting** — plausible opposing texts exist for almost any position or issue (both OT and NT), which enables anyone to use scripture to create their own personal cafeteria-style theology

#### OLD TESTAMENT EXAMPLE: DIVORCE

| DEUTERONOMY 24:1 — THE KEY WORD: "INDECENCY"                                                                                             |              |                                         |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|-----------------------------------------|
| "...if she finds no favor in his eyes because he has found some <i>indecency</i> in her, that he writes her a certificate of divorce..." |              |                                         |
| RABBI                                                                                                                                    | SCHOOL       | INTERPRETATION OF "INDECENCY"           |
| Shammai                                                                                                                                  | Conservative | Adultery only                           |
| Hillel                                                                                                                                   | Liberal      | Any reason the husband deems sufficient |

*Two of Judaism's most prominent legal scholars couldn't agree on the meaning of a single word, even within a "simple" text.*

#### NEW TESTAMENT EXAMPLE 1: BAPTISM

| Is baptism necessary for salvation? |                                        |
|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|
|                                     | SOURCE                                 |
| YES                                 | Acts 2:38, 1 Peter 3:21, Mark 16:16    |
| NO                                  | 1 Cor 1:17, Rom 10:9-10, Luke 23:39-43 |

#### NEW TESTAMENT EXAMPLE 2: RIGHTEOUSNESS

| Do righteous people exist? |                                                                                                 |                                 |
|----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
|                            | SOURCE                                                                                          | NOTES                           |
| YES                        | Matt 9:13/Mark 2:17/Luke 5:32, Mark 6:20, Luke 1:6, Luke 15:7, Luke 23:50, Acts 10:22, Phil 3:6 | This is only a partial list     |
| NO                         | Romans 3:9-10                                                                                   | Loosely references Psalm 14:1-3 |

#### BOTTOM LINE

Sola Scriptura creates a free-for-all environment in which anyone can interpret scripture without any authoritative guardrails. Consequently, Christianity has fractured into countless denominations (and sub-denominations), each claiming scriptural authority.

## III THE ARGUMENT FROM AUTHORSHIP

### III — AUTHORSHIP: PAUL'S CREDIBILITY PROBLEM

*Most of the confusion and divisiveness caused by the Bible has a single source.*

#### STRIKE 1 — FALSE PROPHECY

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 THESS 4:15-17 — EARLIEST NEW TESTAMENT WRITING (~50-51 CE)                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| "For this we declare to you <i>by the word of the Lord</i> , that <b>we who are alive and remain until the coming of the Lord</b> will not precede those who have fallen asleep... we who are alive, who remain, will be caught up together with them in the clouds..." |

- Paul asserted he would be alive when Jesus returned, based on receiving "**the word of the Lord**"
- The New Testament's earliest book thus contains a highly significant failed prediction

#### STRIKE 2 — PAUL VS. JAMES

| WRITER | TEXT              | POSITION                                                                |
|--------|-------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Paul   | Rom 4:3; Gen 15:6 | Justified by faith alone — his entire doctrine is built on one OT verse |
| James  | Jas 2:21-24       | "Justified by works and not by faith alone" — direct rebuttal of Paul   |

- James: Jesus' brother; leader of the Jerusalem believers
- Paul: never met Jesus; didn't meet the sole apostolic qualification stated in Acts 1

#### STRIKE 3 — PAUL VS. PETER

- Peter: publicly appointed by Jesus and given the "keys of the kingdom"; present for Jesus' entire ministry
- Paul: claimed he was appointed in a private vision; openly rebukes Peter in Antioch — calls him a "hypocrite" and accuses him of "not acting consistently with the truth of the gospel" (Gal 2:11-14)
- Even Paul's ministry partner Barnabas sides with Peter
- No biblical record of reconciliation between Paul and Peter

#### JERUSALEM ENDGAME (ACTS 21 - PAUL'S FINAL VISIT TO THE CITY)

- The issue: the Jewish believers in Jerusalem have heard that Paul is anti-Torah and are upset he's in town
- James' plan: urge Paul to undergo a purification rite in the temple to prove he's still Torah-observant
- The plan "fails"; Paul is arrested after his presence in the temple sparks a mob riot

#### THE AFTERMATH

- James is silent after the arrest: no advocacy for Paul, no prison visits, no support
- Paul is sent to Rome all alone, and his ministry effectively ends
- Notable: James' silence may have spoken volumes

#### BOTTOM LINE

Sola Scriptura is compromised by the fact that a large portion of the New Testament was written by someone who was in conflict with the original apostles during his entire ministry.